

BUILDING MY SUPPORT NETWORK # 15

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Demonstrate increased interdependence and self-confidence through autonomous decision-making, honest expression of feelings and ideas, and reduced fear of rejection.
2. Demonstrate healthy communication that is honest, open, and self-disclosing.
3. Identify and get help from supportive others at home, work, and in other settings.
4. Decrease feelings of isolation and assist in reintegration into the community.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE DEPENDENT TRAITS

- Correcting Distorted Thinking
- Forming Stable Relationships
- How Independent Am I?
- Setting and Maintaining Boundaries
- Understanding Codependent Behaviors
- Using My Support Network
- What Do I Need and How Do I Get It?
- Working toward Independence

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Building My Support Network” activity is intended for clients who are socially and emotionally isolated, or who have formed unhealthy, dependent relationships with other people. It works by guiding the client to see interdependence as normal and desirable and to reflect on the positive effects for both helper and helpee. The exercise goes on to lead the client to make concrete plans to break out of isolation and seek help and support from a network of others in a healthy way.

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When people are actively abusing alcohol or other drugs, or practicing addictive behaviors, they often isolate themselves. Reversing that trait is an important part of recovery. Most people who succeed in achieving long-term abstinence do so with the help of others, not alone.

1. When people first come into a treatment program or therapy for an addiction, they may have great difficulty asking anyone for anything, especially for help with a problem. Does this describe you? Why do you think this is difficult?

2. If the situation is reversed, and you meet others who are new to a task in which you have some knowledge and experience, how do you feel if they ask for your help or advice?

3. Do you see others in treatment or early recovery getting help and support from people who have been in recovery longer? Does it change the way you think of these people when they admit that they don't know something and ask someone who does know?

4. What kinds of responses do you usually see them get from the people they ask for help or guidance? Are they responses you would like to get, or give, in a similar situation?

5. What are some areas in which you could use some information, support, and feedback on how you're doing? Please list three such areas—pick things that confuse you or seem difficult:

6. Who knows a lot about those areas? List some people by name, and then circle the categories of people you think would be helpful to you:

Names

Categories

Family members

Friends

_____	Coworkers
_____	Support group members
_____	Mental health professionals
_____	Members of the clergy
_____	Medical professionals

7. Think about how you might ask each of these people for help and support in your recovery. You will probably want to communicate these things:
 - a. What you are trying to accomplish—to stay clean and sober and change your life.
 - b. What goals you have set. These can be things like staying sober for a year, working the 12 Steps, finding six new activities to replace drinking and using, and so on.
 - c. What problems you are having difficulty with at this moment.
 - d. How you feel these people can help you achieve your goals and solve your problems. (Don't ask them to do it all for you, unless it's a special problem and that's their job!)
 - e. Why you chose them to ask for help.
8. When you have identified people who will help you work on your recovery, the next step is to establish a routine with each of them, because most of us are so busy that we fail to get around to things unless they are scheduled. For example, you might meet with a therapist at a set time each week; have a family dinner on certain nights; call a friend at about the same time each weekend; go to a particular meeting daily or weekly; or have lunch with a sponsor regularly. For each of the people you named earlier, when will you meet or talk with them?

Name	When/Where/How I Will Meet or Talk with This Person
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

9. It can also be an important part of your recovery work to help others yourself, in whatever way you can. For example, you might volunteer a few hours a week to do some sort of service work as a volunteer. If you belong to a 12-step group, you can volunteer for chores such as making coffee, setting up furniture, cleaning up after meetings, and so on. What kind of service to others will you include in your recovery program, and when and where will you do it?

Service Task	For Whom	Time	Place
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

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